

Ordinals and Typed Lambda Calculus

Ordinal Notations

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Introduction

Too many numbers to be named

Spector (1955) starts by pointing out that

*Cantor's second ordinal number class is perhaps the simplest example of a set of mathematical objects which cannot all be named in **one** language.*

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Remark

Recall that a language is a subset of words over an alphabet.

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Yes! We can name any natural number by a word over the alphabet $\{0, 1, 2, \dots, 9\}$.

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Can all natural numbers be named in one language?

Yes! We can name any natural number by a word over the alphabet $\{0, 1, 2, \dots, 9\}$.

That was easy because the set of natural numbers is denumerable.

Introduction

Question

Can all real numbers be named in one language?

Notation Systems for the Ordinals below ϵ_0

Theorem

Every ordinal α less than ϵ_0 has a normal form

$$\alpha = \omega^{\beta_1} + \omega^{\beta_2} + \cdots + \omega^{\beta_n},$$

where $\beta_1 \geq \beta_2 \geq \cdots \geq \beta_n$ are ordinals and $\beta_i < \alpha$ (Pohlers 2009, p. 33).

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Definition

From the above theorem, we can name any ordinal less than ϵ_0 by a word over the alphabet $\{+, 0, \omega\}$. By coding these words in natural numbers, we get a **notation system for the ordinals below ϵ_0** (Pohlers 2009, p. 33).

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Remark

The ordinal ϵ_0 is the smallest ordinal that has no a name in terms of ω .

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Representation using trees

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There is a one-to-one correspondence between finite rooted trees and ordinals below ϵ_0 given by (Dershowitz 1993):

- i) The one-node tree represents the ordinal 0.
- ii) The tree with sub-trees representing the ordinals $\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_n$ represents the ordinal $\omega^{\alpha_1} \# \dots \# \omega^{\alpha_n}$.

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Kleene's $\mathcal{O}$

Definition

We inductively define the **notation system** $\mathcal{O}$ and the **well-founded ordering** $<_{\mathcal{O}}$ (Cooper 2004, Definition 16.2.29, p. 358):

- i) We start by giving the ordinal 0 notation 1. Assume all ordinals less than α have been assigned notations, and $<_{\mathcal{O}}$ has been defined on these notations.
- ii) Say $\alpha = \beta + 1$, and β has notation x .

Then α gets notation 2^x and we add $\langle z, 2^x \rangle$ to $<_{\mathcal{O}}$ for each z such that $z = x$ or $z <_{\mathcal{O}} x$ already.

- iii) Say α is a limit ordinal, and $\langle \varphi_e(n) : n \in \mathbb{N} \rangle$ is a list of notations for ordinals with limit α , and $\forall n [\varphi_e(n) <_{\mathcal{O}} \varphi_e(n+1)]$ already.

Then give α notation $3 \cdot 5^e$, and add $\langle z, 3 \cdot 5^e \rangle$ to $<_{\mathcal{O}}$ for all z for which $z <_{\mathcal{O}} \varphi_e(n)$ already, some $n \geq 0$.

Kleene's $\mathcal{O}$

Remark

We could use the notations zero , $\text{succ}(x)$ and $\text{lim}(e)$ instead of the notations 1 , 2^x and $3 \cdot 5^e$.[†]

[†]See, e.g. (Fránzen [2004] 2017).

Constructive Ordinals and Computable Ordinals

Definition

The **constructive ordinals** (second definition) are the ordinals notated by $\mathcal{O}$ (Cooper 2004, Definition 16.2.29, p. 358).

[†]See, e.g. (Cooper 2004, Definition 16.2.25, p. 358), (Rogers [1967] 1992, p. 211) and (Ash and Knight 2000, p. 61).

Constructive Ordinals and Computable Ordinals

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Definition

A countable ordinal is **computable** iff it is finite or it is isomorphic to a computable well-ordering $(A, \prec)$.[†]

[†]See, e.g. (Cooper 2004, Definition 16.2.25, p. 358), (Rogers [1967] 1992, p. 211) and (Ash and Knight 2000, p. 61).

Constructive Ordinals and Computable Ordinals

Theorem

An ordinal α is constructive iff α is a computable ordinal.[†]

[†]See, e.g. (Rogers [1967] 1992, Corollary XIX and Theorem XX, p. 211) and (Ash and Knight 2000, § 4.7, p. 62).

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